the march, it eventually reached Dandi with thousands of Indians joining in. That spark became a raging fire that lit an idea in every Indian's heart. Similarly, Rahul Gandhi was also following in the footsteps of the Mahatma. He, too, was pushed out of the political establishment; he, too, was swimming against the tide within the Congress party organization; and he, too, was trying to make his party and the country find their moral cores. Rahul Gandhi had made similar fledgling attempts before, but they were perceived as symbolic and bitterly caricatured. His visits to the families of farmers who had died by suicide in Vidarbha, or his visits to Batta-Parsol near Delhi, or his dining at a Dalit labourer's home were seen as episodic. But Bharat Jodo was something different. On the face of it, he was merely bridging the yawning divide between the government and the citizens. But he was also trying to tap into something more primal. Since ancient times, walking to connect with people has held tremendous value in India. People innately see the sacrifices and struggle involved in a Yatra as a spiritual activity. As a result, all the criticism Rahul faced for years, from being dismissed as a princeling to a pappu (simpleton), was countered comprehensively. He not only broke out of the image imposed on him, but also connected to independent India like no leader before ever has.

Even though the Bharat Jodo Yatra was largely Rahul Gandhi's, it was also ours. There was an open appeal to all people's organizations and movements to join the Yatra. Even though Yogendra Yadav (the founder of the Swaraj Party) issued the appeal, it was not to be a centralized, national coordination of civil society. Each of us could join as proud representatives of our respective organizations without compromising our identities. Once this was made clear, many individuals and organizations spontaneously sprang into action. The impetus for us was not only to present people's issues that have been ignored for years, but also to connect those aggrieved to Rahul directly. The memory of the Dandi March and the chance to voice their issues to someone senior energized lakhs of Indians. Without waiting for the support of any 'mainstream' media, regardless of political affiliation, millions of Indians utilized social media to join the Yatra. Undoubtedly, the Congress party's social media ecosystem also publicized the Yatra on digital